

INFERTILITY DISORDERS

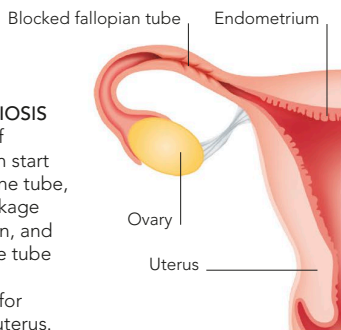
IF A COUPLE IS UNABLE TO CONCEIVE AFTER A YEAR OF HAVING UNPROTECTED SEX, ONE OR BOTH PARTNERS MAY HAVE A FERTILITY PROBLEM. THE LIKELIHOOD OF FERTILITY DISORDERS INCREASES WHEN COUPLES WAIT UNTIL THEY REACH THEIR 30s OR 40s TO START A FAMILY.

DAMAGED FALLOPIAN TUBE

The fallopian tube may become blocked as a result of endometriosis (see p.296), in which fragments of the uterine lining (endometrium) become embedded in the tube tissue. Pelvic inflammatory disease (see p.298), which is often caused by a sexually transmitted infection such as chlamydia (see p.299), may go unnoticed at the time of infection, but scarring due to the inflammation can cause problems with fertility later. An intrauterine contraceptive device can increase the risk of PID developing. Usually, only one fallopian tube is affected; if so, the woman still has a chance to conceive.

ENDOMETRIOSIS

Fragments of endometrium start growing in one tube, causing blockage and distortion, and rendering the tube useless as a passageway for eggs to the uterus.

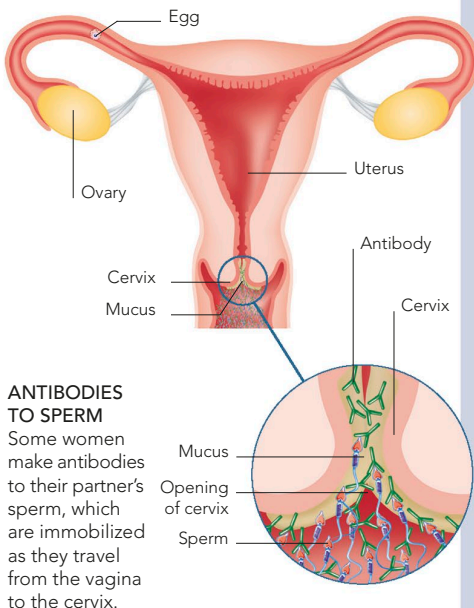


OVULATION PROBLEMS

Any deviation from the normal ovulation pattern can cause problems with fertility. The precise problem can range from complete absence of egg release to infrequent release. Factors that can lead to ovulation problems include pituitary and thyroid gland disorders, polycystic ovary syndrome, long-term use of oral contraceptives, being very over- or underweight, stress, excessive exercise, and premature menopause.

CERVICAL PROBLEMS

The cervix, or neck of the womb, produces mucus that is usually thick; just before ovulation, when the level of oestrogen increases, the mucus turns less viscous to allow sperm to penetrate. If oestrogen levels are low or if there is infection within the reproductive tract, the mucus may remain thick and impregnable to sperm. Another problem that may make the cervix inhospitable is that sometimes a woman's immune system forms antibodies to her partner's sperm, which will then damage or kill the sperm in the cervix. Polyps, fibroids (see p.297), narrowing (stenosis), and distortion are other problems of the cervix that may be related to infertility.



ANTIBODIES TO SPERM

Some women make antibodies to their partner's sperm, which are immobilized as they travel from the vagina to the cervix.